

Session 4: The Origins of Matthew's Gospel

Key Takeaways

- Ancient literature, like Matthew, is usually connected to authoritative figures, but they don't necessarily need to have written it to justify this association.
- Many of the earliest (2nd-3rd century) manuscripts of the gospels are titled "According to Mark/Matthew/Luke/John."
- The earliest Christian communities accepted this account as coming from the tradition of the apostles, channeled through Matthew.

Social Setting, Authorship, and Date of the Gospel According to Matthew

It's important to begin by saying that we have no certain or conclusive evidence regarding the most basic questions about the Gospel of Matthew.

- Who wrote it? The gospel is anonymous; nowhere does it name its author.
- When was it written? Nowhere is a date given in the gospel itself.
- Why or among what communities was it written? No related information is given within the gospel.

The Gospel of Matthew is not, however, unique when it comes to these questions. None of the four gospel accounts contains any explicit information about these things. Even the prologue to Luke ([Luke 1:1-2](#)) and the epilogue to John ([John 21](#)), which contain very precious information about the author and setting of the books, don't answer these questions directly.

Insight into these important questions takes place through a process of induction by reading the gospel itself (internal evidence) and by sifting through all of the earliest quotations or mentions of the Gospel of Matthew in the earliest generations of the Church. But, it turns out, there is a lot to work with on these fronts.

External Evidence About the Origins of the Gospel of Matthew

The Gospel manuscripts have their title "According to Mark/Matthew/Luke/John" in many of the earliest (2nd-3rd century) manuscripts.

Papias, an early 2nd-century bishop in Asia Minor, shares a memory he claims to have learned from the apostles.

"Matthew collected the sayings/matters in the Hebrew language, and each person translated them as he was able."

There is no scholarly consensus about what exactly Papias means, or whether his report is even accurate in the first place.

- While Jesus' words would have been translated from Aramaic into Greek at a pre-Gospel stage, there is no evidence that Matthew is the result of such a process. The original language of the Gospel of Matthew was certainly in Greek, based on the simple fact that some 80% of Mark's Greek account is taken up and edited by Matthew (Mark's Greek reads much more like Hebrew written in Greek, whereas Matthew's Greek is much more stylistic and clean).
- If Matthew was in fact an eyewitness, would he have used 80% of Mark's Greek account?

The Gospel of Matthew is quoted by some of our earliest 2nd-century Christian texts that post-date any New Testament work.

- The *Didache* (ch. 8, 10:5, or ch. 16) quotes Gospel sayings of Jesus in their uniquely Matthean form.
- Ignatius of Antioch (died 108 C.E.) quotes sayings of Jesus in their Matthean form (*Letter to the Smyrneans* 1.1 = Matt 3:15; *Letter to the Philadelphians* 3:1 = Matt. 15:13).

Internal Evidence About the Origins of the Gospel of Matthew

If Matthew adopts Mark as a primary source, and if Mark was written just prior to or after the destruction of the temple in 70 C.E., then this could provide a range of 70s-80s C.E.

The disciple Matthew is uniquely highlighted in this gospel. In Matthew chapter 9, Mark's account of the calling of "Levi" has been changed to "Matthew" in order to connect this Matthew with the Matthew in the list of the twelve disciples in Matthew 10:2 (adopted Mark 3:18).

Mark 2:14 NASB

As he passed by, he saw **Levi the son of Alphaeus** sitting in the tax booth, and he said to him, "Follow me!" And he got up and followed him.

Matthew 9:9 LEB

And as Jesus was going away from there, he saw a man called **Matthew** sitting at the tax booth and said to him, "Follow me!" And he stood up and followed him.

Mark 3:16-18 NASB

¹⁶ And he appointed the twelve: Simon (to whom he gave the name Peter), ¹⁷ and James, the son of Zebedee, and John the brother of James (to them he gave the name Boanerges, which means "Sons of Thunder"); ¹⁸ and Andrew, and Philip, and Bartholomew, and **Matthew**, and Thomas, and James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus, and Simon the Zealot;

Matthew 10:2-3 LEB

² Now these are the names of the twelve apostles: first Simon who is called Peter, and Andrew his brother, James the son of Zebedee, and John his brother, ³ Philip, and Bartholomew, Thomas, and **Matthew the tax collector**, James the son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus,

This curious change has been explained in a number of different ways.

1. Matthew knew, independently of Mark's source tradition, that man's name was Mattathias. It's possible that he knew this because (1a) the Gospel's author was in fact this very Mattathias, or (1b) because he knew this man by two names, Levi and Mattathias. It was not uncommon for Jewish men to go by two names, one more traditional (Levi) and the other more contemporary (Mattathias is a Greek pronunciation of the Hebrew *Mattityah* = "Gift of Yahweh"). See also Saul/Paul, or Simon/Peter.
2. Matthew observed that no one named Levi was among the twelve disciples (listed in [Matt. 10:2-4](#)), while there was indeed a Mattathias (see [Matt. 10:3](#)). He reasoned that because this Mattathias has a narrative dedicated to his being called by Jesus, just as Simon, Andrew, James, and John do (see [Matt. 4:18-22](#)), that Levi was also named Matthew. Note also that Mark names Levi as a "son of Alphaeus," who was likely a brother of "James son of Alphaeus," one of the twelve (see [Mark 3:16-19](#)). It is possible that Levi/Matthew was the brother of James, so that half of Jesus' twelve disciples were actually brothers: Simon/Peter and Andrew, James and John, James and Levi/Matthew.

Matthew clearly assumes his audience is an observant Jewish one that cares very much about true observance of the commands in the Torah.

- The Torah case studies in [ch. 5](#)
- The disputes over true Sabbath observance in [12:1-7](#) and [12:8-21](#)
- The critique of the Pharisees' interpretation of Torah in [5:20](#) and [23:23](#)

Matthew also clearly reflects a conviction that Jesus' focus on Israel was for a time and that after the resurrection, the Kingdom of God is fully inclusive of non-Israelites. Inclusion of the nations is a significant theme in Matthew.

- The diverse crowds in [4:25](#)
- The Roman centurion in [8:5-13](#)
- The [Isaiah 42](#) quote in [12:17-21](#)
- The Canaanite woman in [15:21-28](#)
- The great commission to baptize and teach the nations in [28:18-20](#) (Notice he doesn't say "and circumcise the nations," which shows the influence of the apostolic decree in [Acts 15](#) and an alignment with Paul's gentile mission.)

Matthew reflects bitter hostility toward the city of Jerusalem and the Pharisees as illegitimate leaders of Israel (see [Matt. 23](#)). This hostility likely comes from the growing tension during the late 1st century between Jewish followers of Jesus and Jewish leaders who aren't open to the mission to the Gentiles.

Matthew uniquely highlights the region of "Syria" as coming under the influence of Jesus' mission.

- "Nazarene" (from [Matt. 2:23](#)) was and still is a Syrian term for "Christian."
- Syria is uniquely mentioned by Matthew as among the places from which people came to hear and see Jesus ([Matt. 4:24](#)).
- The woman who is called "Syrian-Phonecian" in [Mark 7:26](#) is called the "Canaanite" woman in [Matt. 15:22](#), the term that Phonecians used to describe themselves in their own Semitic language.
- We know from [Acts 10-15](#) that Antioch was a prominent multicultural hub for the Jesus movement in the years 50-80 C.E., in a network of churches that began out of messianic Jewish synagogues. This is a

plausible setting for the production of such a work.

The Gospel of Matthew is the product of an extremely learned community of scholars who were multilingual (Greek, Latin, Hebrew, and Aramaic) and who were deeply immersed in Israel's Scriptures. It's not beyond imagination that the disciple Matthew was an aged and revered figure in such a community (we know Peter ended up there, see [Gal. 2:11-14](#)).

In the notes that follow, I will use the name "Matthew" to refer to the messianic Jewish scholar who produced this amazing work, along with the broader Christian community and scribal network in which he worshipped, studied, and wrote. Whether or not it was the Apostle Matthew, the account stems from the eyewitness testimony of the apostles (through Mark and the teaching traditions that Matthew received), and the work was accepted as apostolic by the earliest generations of Jesus' followers.

Reflection Question

Do we know who wrote Matthew's Gospel? What internal and external evidence do we have about the authorship of Matthew? How important are these questions to you?